Cabbie from Calcutta

By Robert Mauro

INTRODUCTION

RAGGIE:	*Immigration: Noun: (with enthusiasm) the act of coming to a foreign country in order to settle there.*
MRS. HARTFORD:	*Foreigner: Noun: One who is from a foreign country or place; (scathingly) an outsider.*
RAGGIE:	*Calcutta: the largest city in India; (sadly) suffers from poverty and overcrowding.*
MRS. HARTFORD:	*Cabbie: Noun: an informal name for a (with distaste) taxi driver.*
BOTH:	*"The Cabbie from Calcutta" by Robert Mauro*

Four chairs facing audience form the front and rear seats of RAGGI's cab. RAGGI sits reading The WALL STREET JOURNAL as he waits for a fare.

RAGGI: Look at this. Once more Polaroid and IBM are up. This is up, that is up. Good, great America. The land of much wondrous opportunity. Raggi, the cabbie from Calcutta, will be a very, very rich man someday. I don't spend all my life driving this hick. . . or is it hack? Well, whatever it is, it's a necessity for Raggi now. True, it is also one big pain in the buttock, but then so was riding that blinkin' water buffalo back in Bombay. At least here you get paid. There all I got was bites by that infernal beast. *(Paging through paper)* And does Raggi see any water buffalo stock in this wondrous paper of the great American dream? No. Thank the great lord Rama. But Raggi sees much stock in many interesting things. Many. My heavens! Look at Sony. Sony is truly no baloney. *(Just then MRS. HARTFORD enters.)*

MRS. HARTFORD: *(She walks up to RAGGI's cab and peeks in.)* Cabbie? Yoo-hoo. Hello.

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(Annoyed, she shouts) Cabbie!

RAGGI: *(Jumps and puts down his paper quickly)* Oh, yes, dear lady. That is my middle name.

MRS. HARTFORD: Cabbie is your middle name?

RAGGI: Well, actually my middle name, it is Gandhi, after the great one. But in America, dear lady, it is Cabbie. You can call me Fred, you can call me Red - but when you need a cabbie, please, dear lady, call me anytime cabbie.

MRS. HARTFORD: *(In a hurry, bored)* Yes, yes. How nice. *(Shakes her head)* Another alien. Good lord, the country is full of them.

RAGGI: You telling, Raggi. In India we have your basic Indian. But not in America. Here one person can never tell from where the other is coming or to where he or she is going. It's a very curious place America, but very great. I am proud to be an alien in this great, wondrous land of America. God bless the Grand Canyon and Bruce Springsteen, who I hear was born in the U.S.A.

MRS. HARTFORD: Yes, well some seem to think so. As for me, I'd just like to get this trip over with as soon as possible. Do you understand my meaning, cabbie?

RAGGI: Oh,yes. Very well, misses. Yes, dear lady. And where can Raggi take you?

MRS. HARTFORD: I'm on my way to Wall Street

RAGGI: Good golly! Ah! Yes! Oh, how wonderful. The great Wall Street. *(Holds up paper)* It is all here in black and write.

MRS. HARTFORD: That's black and white.

RAGGI: Oh, yes, to be sure. That, too. Is it not amazing how IBM and Polaroid are always up? *(Holds up the paper)*

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MRS. HARTFORD: Oh, good heavens, not another one.

RAGGI: *(As he starts up his cab, we hear sound of engine revving up.)* Another what?

MRS. HARTFORD: Another dirt-poor alien overly impressed by our capitalistic system.

RAGGI: Oh. Well, one is truly amazed by such things when one's family and friends live on a very few rupees a year, and who must eat - but who have no money to buy food. Slow, fast, or microwaved. And, dear lady, as a result, you don't want to know what we poor folk must eat. It is not a pretty sight, I assure you.

MRS. HARTFORD: I'll bet.

RAGGI: This would be a good bet. Truly our daily bread, it is not what you call your microwave gourmet variety.

MRS. HARTFORD: Yes, yes. Well, so you've picked yourself up by the proverbial bootstraps and have come to America for our microwave TV dinners and our *(Fans herself)* non-air-conditioned taxi cabs? Is that it?

RAGGI: Oh, the air conditioner is on full bust, but it's as hot as buzzards out there. New York is worse than Calcutta in summer.

MRS. HARTFORD: I'll agree with you there. So you've come to America to make your fortune? Is that part of your great American dream? Besides the TV dinners.

RAGGI: That is, indeed, part of what you call it, my American dream. But there is also McDonald's and the Great Cornell.

MRS. HARTFORD: The Great Cornell? What Cornell is that?

RAGGI: Cornell Sanders.

MRS. HARTFORD: I should have guessed.

RAGGI: Finger lickin' good, you know. Yes, indeed. And in two very pleasant styles - regular and crispy. Truly remarkable. And one is also

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entitled to a creamy rich mashed potato treat and one amazingly good biscuit. Is this not truly amazing?

MRS. HARTFORD: If you're into fast food.

RAGGI: Oh, yes. In India there is only fast food.

MRS. HARTFORD: There is? Really?

RAGGI: Oh, truly. One must run very fast to catch it, or one has no fast food. Here the Cornell catches it for you.

MRS. HARTFORD: How interesting. Are we almost there? *(She mumbles the next words.)* I hope.

RAGGI: Look!

MRS. HARTFORD: *(Braces herself in a panic, thinking she's about to be in a tremendous crash - we hear brakes screech and horns blow)* WHAT?

RAGGI: Foot-long dogs sold right in the street!

MRS. HARTFORD: Foot-long dogs? Oh, you mean the Sabret stand there?

RAGGI: Yes, yes. They even have a truly wonderful umbrella for the monsoons. In India we have many monsoons, but no truly delicious foot-long sabret dogs with chili, mustard, relish, sauerkraut and such wonderful umbrellas.

MRS. HARTFORD: It's a darn shame.

RAGGI: Yes, yes. Did I tell you about my trip to see the lady?

MRS. HARTFORD: What lady is that?

RAGGI: The great lady. The statue.

MRS. HARTFORD: In the Metropolitan Museum of Art?

RAGGI: No, no. In the truly wonderful harbor of the great metropolis. The lady Liberty.

MRS. HARTFORD: Oh, that lady.

RAGGI: Yes, that lady. *(Long pause, then)* So aren't you going to ask me

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about my trip to see the lady?

MRS. HARTFORD: I wasn't planning to. But if you insist... So how was your trip to see the lady, cabbie?

RAGGI: I'm glad you asked. and please call me Raggi.

MRS. HARTFORD: Ragoo?

RAGGI: No. *Raggeeee. (Spells it)* R-A-G-G-I. The good old boys down at the garage, at the pepper mine

MRS. HARTFORD: Salt mine.

RAGGI: Huh?

MRS. HARTFORD: You mean salt mine. It's salt mine, not pepper mine.

RAGGI: It is?

MRS. HARTFORD: It is.

RAGGI: This English is a very big pain in the buttock.

MRS. HARTFORD: Butt.

RAGGI: But what?

MRS. HARTFORD: Butt. *(Spells it)* B-U-T-T. Butt. The idiom is not pain in the buttock, but rather pain in the butt. Another bit of America's gift to the free world.

RAGGI: So that's what it is . . .

MRS. HARTFORD: That's what what is?

RAGGI: An idiom. I know many of America's great idioms.

MRS. HARTFORD: I know many of America's great idiots.

RAGGI: You do?

MRS. HARTFORD: You're darn tootin'.

RAGGI: *(Turns and points to her)* Yes!

MRS. HARTFORD: *(Bracing herself-as we hear brakes screech and horns blow.)* Look where you're going! You're not driving an ox cart now!

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RAGGI: *(Looking at the road ahead, dodges a truck - loud screech of brakes and horns)* Hit the dock!

MRS. HARTFORD: You mean hit the deck!

RAGGI: Deck, dock. Here one has a wondrous variety of possible obstacles to hit. In India the only thing you hit is a sacred cow or a water buffalo.

MRS. HARTFORD: Don't they have any cars?

RAGGI: Oh, yes. But in my little village outside of Calcutta we have no cars, no roads. We barely have any villagers. Fortunately we are very lucky to be in walking distance of the great city.

MRS. HARTFORD: Just a few blocks out of town, are you?

RAGGI: No, walking distance.

MRS. HARTFORD: That's what I meant. Walking distance. A few blocks.

RAGGI: Oh, no, dear lady. In India walking distance is any distance one can walk and not get trampled by a sacred cow or eaten by a man-eating tiger. I lived thirty-seven miles out of town.

MRS. HARTFORD: Good heavens! What do you do if you run out of milk in the middle of the night?

RAGGI: Yes, telling me about flit.

MRS. HARTFORD: Not flit, it. Tell me about *it.*

RAGGI: I'm telling you already. Hold your haunches. This could be a real boomer.

MRS. HARTFORD: I think you mean it could be a real bummer.

RAGGI: Truly.

MRS. HARTFORD: Very dangerous walking in the India jungle at night for a container of milk, huh?

RAGGI: No. Very dangerous milking a sleeping water buffalo.

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MRS. HARTFORD: You're serious.

RAGGI: I'm joking, dear lady. But we manage.

MRS. HARTFORD: I guess. But to be perfectly honest, I am not at all happy by all you foreigners coming to my country to rip us off.

RAGGI: Raggi rips no one. I keep this cab clean, and not even one lady has ever torn or ripped her famous, fabulous Leggs or silky soft, sheer

MRS. HARTFORD: That's not what I mean! I was not talking about pantyhose!

RAGGI: You said Raggi rip off people.

MRS. HARTFORD: I meant cheat them! As in take their money unfairly and illegally! Cheat!

RAGGI: *(A bit annoyed)* Cheat? Raggi never cheat a single person. I am an honest man! My father was an honest man and his father before him. We are good people. We are not cheats.

MRS. HARTFORD: Then you're not much of an American. Here it's dog eat dog.

RAGGI: In India it's man eat dog, occasionally lizard. Now *that* is *very* fast food.

MRS. HARTFORD: I think I'm going to be sick. :

RAGGI: If you have to eat dog, you'd be very sick. :

MRS. HARTFORD: *Stop talking about food!*

RAGGI: OK. What do you want me to talk about? Perhaps the future of pork belly options on Wall Street? Maybe margin buying and selling? Securities and Muni Bonds are good. Or, perhaps, we can rap right on about. . . my favorite. .. insider trading scandals. Very shifty, you Americans. You do that in Calcutta, they cut off more than your credit.

MRS. HARTFORD: Look, Rummie or Ronnie, or whatever your name is, just get me to Wall Street. OK?

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RAGGI: It's Raggi. With two g's.

MRS. HARTFORD: *Just get me* to *Wall Street!*

RAGGI: In a gypsy!

MRS. HARTFORD: What? This is a gypsy cab?

RAGGI: No. A fast cab. You know: in a gypsy. Pronto.

MRS. HARTFORD: Good gracious! You mean in *a jiffy,* not gypsy.

RAGGI: Oh. I see. A jiffy. Like peanut butter? Is Jiffy peanut butter fast food?

MRS. HARTFORD: I have no idea.

RAGGI: It sounds like a fast food.

MRS. HARTFORD: You're kidding, of course. Tell me you're kidding.

RAGGI: Of course.

MRS. HARTFORD: Another bit of Indian humor?

RAGGI: Another bit of Raggi's humor.

MRS. HARTFORD: So Raggi, how does an immigrant from Calcutta make his fortune in the Big Apple?

RAGGI: One works his B-U-T-T off. It is no picnic this Big Apple.

MRS. HARTFORD: I'm sure. Do you plan the cabbie business as your life's work?

RAGGI: No, no. I am enrolled at Columbia University. I am some day becoming a system analyst.

MRS. HARTFORD: YOU... you mean you're a computer programmer?

RAGGI: You bet! Yes. I am very well knowing of *Cobol, Fortran, APL* and *Focus.* I'm even good at Space Invaders.

MRS. HARTFORD: I didn't even think they had computers in India - let alone video games.

RAGGI: Of course we do. And here, too. I'm not going to be driving this hick

MRS. HARTFORD: Hick?

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RAGGI: This cab.

MRS. HARTFORD: You mean hack-H-A-C-K.

RAGGI: I knew it. Hack. Anyhow, someday I'll be working on Wall Street in the electronic data processing section of Whitney, Wainwright, Wagner and Hartford.

MRS. HARTFORD: *My ex-husband's company?*

RAGGI: *(Ironic)* No?

MRS. HARTFORD: YES!

RAGGI: Imagine that. Only in America. Small world, huh?

MRS. HARTFORD: Too small.

RAGGI: They say it's a global village. Soon we'll all be one. ,

MRS. HARTFORD: How thrilling.

RAGGI: Yes. Soon I'll be raking in the big shmucks.

MRS. HARTFORD: I think you mean big bucks.

RAGGI: Yes, that, too.

MRS. HARTFORD: You couldn't do that in India?

RAGGI: In India a person of my cast can do only two things.

MRS. HARTFORD: And what are they?

RAGGI: Milk the water buffalo and feed the water buffalo. It is a very limited job market with no IRA fund, no major medical and absolutely no dental plan.

MRS. HARTFORD: Good heavens! What if you should get kicked by a water buffalo? What do you do?

RAGGI: You kick him back.

MRS. HARTFORD: In America if you get kicked by a water buffalo, you sue the owner and buy a condo in Beverly Hills on the settlement.

RAGGI: Is this not truly the land of opportunity?

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MRS. HARTFORD: Truly.

RAGGI: God bless America.

MRS. HARTFORD: Yes. I, too, love America. In my own way.

RAGGI: Well, here we are, dear lady.

MRS. HARTFORD: *(Getting out, hands RAGGI money and a quarter tip)* My fare, and here's a quarter tip for you.

RAGGI: Truly God bless America. A whole two butts!

MRS. HARTFORD: That's two *bits.*

RAGGI: Right, no butt's about it.

MRS. HARTFORD: You mean you're not offended by such a small tip?

RAGGI: Small? Listen, this is better than what you get for driving a rajah on an elephant to Delhi.

MRS. HARTFORD: You're all right, Rags old boy. *(She exits.)*

RAGGI: *(Puts the quarter in his pocket, then opens the paper.)* Now let's see how many penny stocks I can buy for a quarter. Good golly. That last penny stock I bought took a real flying leap. Bought this cab company on that one. *(Curtain falls as RAGGI laughs and reads the WALL STREET JOURNAL.)*

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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